

Our group photo for the 4th Annual Vesak at the White House, a tradition my mother established in 2020

As a founding member of the Buddhist youth community of the International Buddhist Association of America, it was great to attend this year's Vesak celebration at the White House. This important gathering marks the fourth year in a row that the Biden administration has recognized and celebrated this sacred Buddhist holiday, which is a historic first for Buddhists in America.



Being the first Buddhist American youth at the White House for Vesak

The White House's recognition of the Vesak holiday demonstrates a commitment for Buddhists in America, but also serves as an underlying symbol of our religious freedom in the United States. This recognition is very meaningful to me personally, for also for the nearly three million Buddhists in the USA- not to mention the hundreds of millions world-wide. It’s not just a

formal acknowledgement for all of us, but a sign that the United States has become a place where the Buddhist wisdom that has come to America in waves over the last 100 years is really beginning to thrive. For me it felt really special as my grandfather, Tarthang Tulku, was one of the first Tibetan teachers to establish Buddhism in the States in the 1960's, and has worked hard this past fifty years to preserve important texts and lay the groundwork for Buddhism to flourish in a new land.

My family continues this legacy through their involvement in educational and spiritual organizations. Both of my parents play key roles at Dharma College and the Light of Buddhadharma Foundation, carrying on the work my grandfather started. Their efforts focus on translating ancient Buddhist teachings into a form that resonates with modern seekers, bringing the essence of the Buddha's wisdom to contemporary life.



I'm in Bodhgaya at 7 years old getting ready to offer a ceremonial scarf at a Buddhist ceremony called the Nyingma Monlam.

The teachings of the Buddha, which focus on mindfulness, compassion, and a deep understanding of lived experience are very relevant to the challenges faced by young people nowadays. In a world of uncertainty, division, and environmental change, the Buddha's wisdom provides a way to build emotional strength, find greater purpose, and contribute to positive social outcomes. Meditation can help young people manage their emotions and deal with stress, which is a common problem in the fast-paced modern world. Additionally, Buddha’s teachings can help us all resist excessive desires and develop a positive mindset, further improving our well being. Being a first year business undergraduate at Tulane University, I am proud to share about my roots as a Buddhist American. You might wonder how a fraternity boy might be interested in Buddhist mindfulness practices, but I see all around me a world where the message of the ancient wisdom traditions is more relevant than ever.

It's great to see this holiday get more attention,for this continued celebration shows people worldwide how Buddha’s teachings are universal, how they can help everyone, regardless of faith or background, and how they can provide guidance in these tough times. Hopefully this will inspire other institutions to recognize and celebrate Vesak as well. That would be a wonderful way to honor the diverse religious and cultural traditions that make our world richer.



If any young people would like to connect with other Buddhist youth, they can check out our new Instagram and Facebook accounts: Instagram: buddhistyouthofamerica; Facebook: https://www.facebook.com/BuddhistYouthofAmerica/. These online platforms will provide a community for young Buddhists to share their experiences and support one another on the spiritual path. I'd love for anyone reading this to reach out to me if they would like to get involved or just want to see how we can connect: dorje.dixey@gmail.com.